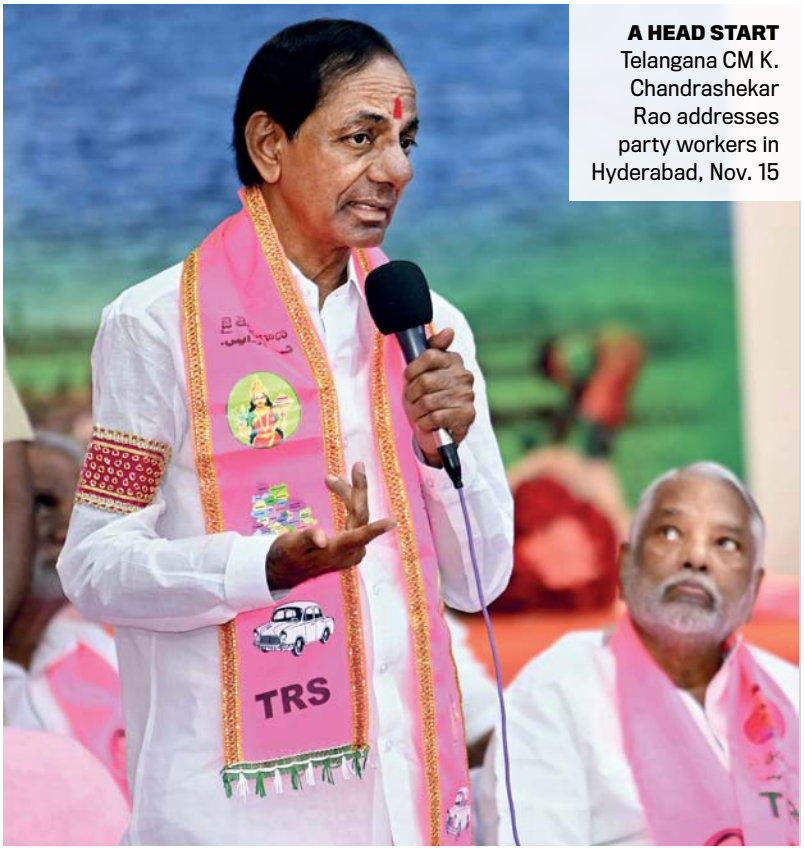
TELANGANA

WAR OF DHARMA

By Amarnath K. Menon



A HEAD START Telangana CM K. Chandrashekar Rao addresses party workers in Hyderabad, Nov. 15

ANI

If rival parties expected the Telangana Rashtra Samithi's (TRS) slim 10,000-vote victory margin in the crucial Munugode assembly bypoll to have sapped the will of its supremo K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR), they miscalculated terribly. If anything, the near-win seems to have only spurred the Telangana chief minister to go all guns blazing into campaign mode for the assembly election, even if it's a year away. Eyeing a third straight term in power, KCR has declared a 'dharma yuddh' (righteous war) on the BJP, now often seen as its main political adversary in the state. He exhorted party workers to wage a fierce battle against the fast-growing saffron party in order to "save the democratic system".

All his pronouncements shone with the confidence that comes to those who have everything at stake. "Every party worker should become a KCR and confront them. We need not fear or hesitate to call out their misdeeds.... They are becoming a threat to the entire nation," he told second-rung TRS leaders on November 15. He ruled out advancing the election like he had done six months before his first term as CM was to end in 2018. For good measure, to quell any misgivings that might perchance infect the ranks, he added that most sitting TRS MLAs will contest from their constituencies. What he rolled out, in effect, was a full 365-day battle plan.

The year ahead will be used to ensure that welfare and development programmes reach the last mile: data on all beneficiaries is being collated to cultivate a connect with the electorate at the polling booth level. Besides, the TRS chief plans to work on winning back the support of sections he alienated over the past eight years. The 'saturation strategy' that proved useful in Munugode—now christened the 'Munugode model'—will be deployed across the state, with each key party worker reaching out to 100 voters even as the MLAs focus on their respective constituencies. A databank of voter in-charges is being created to enable smooth coordination.

KCR will hold meetings with ministers and MLAs every fortnight, besides online interactions with local leaders—a significant shift considering the state cabinet met just four times in 2022. MLAs and constituency in-charges will host *athmeeya sammelans* (community meetings) to address grievances and connect with millennials unaware of the TRS-led statehood campaign that led to the formation of Telangana. The Munugode model is also about building political and social coalitions: the alliance with the CPI and the CPI(M) played a decisive role there. While staying with that model, KCR plans to plot out the TRS's own strengths and weaknesses in every constituency.

KCR HAS DECLARED A 'DHARMA YUDDH' (WAR OF RIGHTEOUSNESS) ON THE BJP A YEAR AHEAD OF THE STATE ELECTION IN DECEMBER 2003

Telangana's financial health remains a big worry, though, because of the Centre's adverse responses on grants and the state's share of taxes. Recruitment of teachers for schools and colleges as well as their salaries and pensions have been getting delayed. Corrective measures on these fronts will be necessary to minimise the impact of anti-incumbency and build a positive campaign.

For the BJP, Telangana is a crucial arena: after Karnataka, it's the second flank through which it hopes to prise open the South. A good showing here will carry a lot of material and symbolic